# Chapter One: The Ferry at Dusk

The ferry left the north bank an hour before dark, and the ferryman lit his lantern before the boat had cleared the reeds. He did it every evening, whether or not anyone was waiting on the far side.

Most nights the crossing took twenty minutes. The river was wide there and slow, and the current pulled the boat a little downstream, so that he had to aim for the old willow and let the water carry him to the landing. Passengers who had made the crossing before liked to watch him do it, and the ones who had not always asked why he steered for the tree and not the

dock, until he showed them where the current would leave them if he did.

He kept a ledger of every crossing in a tin box under the bench. It held the date, the weather, the number of passengers, and a line or two about each of them, written small so that one page would last a week. Nobody had asked him to keep it. He said that a river forgets everyone who crosses it, and that somebody ought to remember them for a while.

On the evening this story begins, there was one passenger on the south bank: a girl of about twelve with a suitcase tied shut with string and a letter she held in both hands, as if the wind might

take it from her. She asked whether the boat went as far as the mill. He told her that it went only across, and that the mill was a long walk from the landing, but that he would show her the path.

She sat at the front of the boat with the suitcase on her knees. Halfway over she asked what the lantern was for, since the sky was still light enough to see the far bank. He said that it was not for him.

It was for anyone on the water who had lost the landing, and for anyone on the bank who was wondering whether the ferry was still running.

The girl thought about that for the rest of the crossing. When they reached the willow she watched the current take the boat, just as he had said it would, and she laughed when it bumped against the landing as gently as a cat against a door.

He tied the boat up and walked with her as far as the first bend in the path. There he gave her the lantern, because the walk to the mill went through the wood and would be dark long before she

reached it. She promised to bring it back in the morning.

That night he crossed the river without a light for the first time in eleven years. He wrote the crossing in the ledger by the glow of the stove, and under it, in letters a little larger than usual, he wrote that the lantern was out on loan.